

Read **Text A** and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2** on the question paper.

Text A: The Dog on Platform Six

Daniel Mercer works at Belford Station, where an unaccompanied dog appears daily.

- 1 The dog arrived with the 18:17 train, although nobody ever saw him get off it. One moment Platform Six was empty except for scraps of newspaper tumbling along the rails; the next, he was sitting beneath the station clock, watching the passengers spill through the doors. I first noticed him on a wet Monday in November. He was medium-sized, mud-coloured and slightly too thin. Rain had darkened his fur, and one ear folded at the tip as if someone had once creased it. "Another stray," said Lena, the cleaner, steering her trolley past. When I approached, the dog retreated precisely three steps. He did not growl. He simply measured the distance between us and held it, his amber eyes calm and watchful. Around his neck was a pale strip where a collar had recently been. 5
- 2 Before I could telephone anyone, the departure whistle sounded. The dog inspected each closing door and trotted to the rear of the train. He watched its red lights shrink into the rain, then slipped through a gap in the fence. He returned on Tuesday. And Wednesday. Always shortly before 18:17, always to the same square beneath the clock. He studied every face emerging from the train. Once, a tall man in a green coat stepped down and the dog's whole body sprang forward. When the stranger turned, hope drained from the animal as visibly as air from a punctured balloon. 10
- 3 By Friday, the staff had begun calling him Six. Lena brought chicken, which he accepted only after the train had gone. A ticket inspector left a box beside the waiting-room radiator, but Six never entered it. He belonged to the platform and to that single, stubborn hour. I told myself he was not my responsibility. Evenings were relentless: delayed services, faulty machines and passengers convinced I controlled the weather. Station rules were clear about strays. Still, at 18:15, I found myself looking up from the barrier. I had started measuring my own evenings by his arrival. 15
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- 4 The following Monday, the 18:17 was cancelled. A fallen tree had blocked the line, and the announcement brought a chorus of groans. Six sat beneath the clock while rainwater gathered in shining beads on his whiskers. At 18:25, he began to pace. Ten minutes later, he ran to the platform edge, then back to the clock. His confidence seemed to be unravelling. I crouched and held out my hand. This time he seized my sleeve gently between his teeth and pulled. "What is it?" I asked, feeling ridiculous. Six hurried towards the footbridge and looked back. When I did not follow, he returned and tugged again. Lena glanced at the clock, then silently took my place at the barrier. 25
- 5 Beyond the station fence, Six moved swiftly through streets glazed with rain, pausing at every corner to check I was still there. The shops gave way to narrow terraces. At last, he stopped outside a neglected house with a blue door. Dead leaves covered its steps, and unopened letters pressed against the glass. Six scratched once at the door, then sat down. A neighbour peered from behind her curtain. "Are you looking for Mr Vale?" she called. "An ambulance took him away nearly three weeks ago. His daughter came, but she couldn't find the dog." She named a hospital in the next town—the final stop of the 18:17 service. I looked from the letters to Six. He was watching the road, not the house. I remembered the faces he had searched and the exactness of his arrival. The pieces settled quietly into place. 30
35
- 6 I borrowed rope from the station storeroom and made a loose lead. Six objected, twisting away and planting his paws against the pavement. Yet when we reached Platform Six, he became still. The replacement train was due at 19:10; we had just enough time. During the journey, Six sat rigidly beside my feet. Each time the brakes sighed, he looked up. Passengers smiled at him, but he paid them no attention. At the final stop, he pulled me through the doors so forcefully that I nearly lost my cap. 40

- 7 The receptionist listened patiently, though her expression suggested railway employees did not usually arrive after dark with dripping dogs. Mr Vale had been transferred to a rehabilitation centre beside the hospital. Animals were not permitted inside. Perhaps Six understood the disappointment in her voice. His tail became motionless. I was considering how to get him back onto the train when a nurse stopped. "There's a courtyard outside his room," she said. "If the dog remained outdoors, I suppose no rule would technically be broken." We followed her around the building. Through a lighted ground-floor window, an elderly man sat staring down at his motionless hands. The nurse tapped on the glass. 45
- 8 Mr Vale looked up. For a second, nothing happened. Then Six gave a low sound—not a bark, but something squeezed from deep inside him—and hurled himself towards the window. His paws struck the glass. The old man's face changed completely. He pushed himself upright, one hand pressed to the pane, laughing and crying at once. The glass kept them apart, yet neither seemed to notice it. I stepped back beneath the dripping trees, suddenly embarrassed to be watching something so private. All week I had imagined that Six was waiting for a train. I had been wrong. 50
- Trains were merely the rhythm by which he measured hope. 55

RUFUS

Read **Text A, The Dog on Platform Six**, in the insert and answer **Question 1** and **Question 2**.

Question 1

- (a) From paragraph 1, identify **one** detail which suggests that the dog had previously belonged to someone.
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- [1]
- (b) Suggest a reason why Six always returned shortly before the 18:17 train arrived. (line 11)
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- [1]
- (c) From paragraph 3, identify **two** things the station staff did to care for Six.
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- [2]
- (d) From paragraph 4, give **two** details which show that Six becomes increasingly distressed when the train does not arrive.
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- [2]
- (e) **Using your own words**, explain what the text means by 'His confidence seemed to be unravelling'. (line 24)
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- [2]

- (f) In paragraph 6, how does Six feel during the train journey?

Give **two** details from the text to support your answer.

Six's feeling

details

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[3]

- (g) (i) Why was Daniel considering how to 'get him back onto the train'? (line 46)

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[1]

- (ii) Why did Daniel not take Six back to the station?

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[1]

- (h) Explain **using your own words** Daniel's different feelings and opinions about Six.

Give **three** details from anywhere in the text to support your answer.

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[3]

[Total: 16]

Question 2

- (a) Explain why the writer uses the word 'glazed' rather than 'wet' in the expression 'streets glazed with rain'. (line 28)

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[1]

- (b) What two impressions does the writer convey to the reader in the sentence: 'Dead leaves covered its steps, and unopened letters pressed against the glass.' (lines 30–31)

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[2]

- (c) Read this sentence from the text:

'When the stranger turned, hope drained from the animal as visibly as air from a punctured balloon.' (lines 13–14)

What effects does the writer suggest about Six's reaction by comparing it to 'air from a punctured balloon'? Give two effects.

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[2]

- (d) Read this sentence from the text:

'For a second, nothing happened.' (line 51)

What does the writer want the reader to feel at this point in the story?

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[1]

- (e) Identify one example from the text below of how the writer uses language effectively to convey the emotions of Six or Mr Vale during their reunion:

'Then Six gave a low sound—not a bark, but something squeezed from deep inside him—and hurled himself towards the window. His paws struck the glass. The old man's face changed completely. He pushed himself upright, one hand pressed to the pane, laughing and crying at once.' (lines 51–54)

Explain the impression the writer creates in the example you have identified.

example

explanation

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[3]

[Total: 9]